

# HES

## WETLAND MEADOW RESTORATION

### WHAT IS A WETLAND?

A Wetland is an environmentally sensitive area. It is a distinct semi-aquatic ecosystem in which the plants are flooded or saturated permanently or seasonally.



### CONNECTION

When students develop a connection to nature they experience academic, social-emotional, and well-being benefits.



### WHY NATIVE PLANTS?

Native plants have co-evolved with native animals into a complex food web. Native plants are essential for reproductive cycles as host plants, like Monarch butterflies need milkweed. Native birds depend on native insect larvae to feed their newly hatched chicks.

### THE PROJECT

ecoPTO has partnered with Green Matters, Inc who has generously provided the grant for this project. This project is a student-centered ecosystem restoration project. The restoration site is located in the southeast corner of the school property, adjacent to the parking lot. The location is mapped as wetlands. It is perpetually soggy with some inundation year round. There are some native plants (cattails) but it is mostly mowed lawn.



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### SITE PREPERATION

The site was prepared for planting by smothering the existing lawn. This was achived with layers of cardboard and woodchips delivered by Shier Tree.



### HES Wetland Meadow Species (common names):

Swamp Rose Mallow  
Poverty Grass  
Northern Sea Oats  
Swamp Sunflower  
Dense Blazing Star  
Red Columbine  
Allegheny Monkey Flower  
Scarlet Bee Balm  
Blue Vervain  
Winterberry Holly  
Red-twig dogwood  
Blue False Indigo  
Virginia Mountain Mint  
Steeplebush  
Buttonbush  
Elderberry  
Northern blue iris  
Golden Ragwort



Volunteers from HES, Sourland Conservancy, FoHVOS, Mercer County Parks Commission, Native Habitat Collaborative and My Backyard at Nectars prepared the site for the students to plant.



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With the Green Matters, Inc grant secured, ecoPTO began planning a hands-on planting event. In partnership with HES administration, ecoPTO planned for every HES student to plant on November 26, 2025. Every thirty minutes a cohort of students would come to the meadow. Upon arrival, ecoPTO led a breathing exercise to help keep the students focus. ecoPTO led each cohort in a discussion about gratitude for our earth, food that we enjoy and food that animals eat. We focused on birds eat, and how this wetland meadow will provide food for birds even in the winter. After this introduction, the students were partnered with our volunteers for the planting efforts. Many of the volunteers are environmental educators, land stewards, and passionate native plant gardeners. Each volunteer brought their own experience to the discussions which ranged from what insects will visit these plants, to the mycelium in the soil and extensive native plant root systems. The work will continue in the spring as we prepare another area to be planted with diverse species.

